

Socialist Party within the Congress. It was indeed surprising that JP being a defender of radical Marxism was influenced by Gandhi's non-violence.

I remember an episode in JP's life which shows his great spirit. It was in 1942, when he was imprisoned in Hazaribagh and all his other associates were also in jail. JP was worried about the movement and wanted to participate in the call for freedom. He devised an escape plan which is one of the most audacious I have ever heard. Along with his friends Yogendra Shukla, Ram Nandan Mishra and Gulali Sonar, he planned

the journey. They escaped unscathed in the end, and for us, the tale embodies his uncommon courage.

JP's involvement in the political scene later became more pronounced. The call of Congress *chhodo* (quit) resounded, leading to the formation of the Socialist Party. The party broke away from the Congress and stood in opposition. JP was known for his organisational skills. He was someone who could get his views across to the crowd as no one else could. I remember people screaming "Jayaprakash" in unison when he faced congregations. By

JP leading hordes of students on a silent march through the streets, with everyone's mouths covered and their hands tied behind their backs. It was a protest that left a deep impact on everyone. From then, the sobriquet Lok Nayak sat comfortably on him.

I was in college at that time. It was a charged atmosphere. I met him at a *dharna*. A couple of us were introduced to him. It was perhaps one of the greatest moments of my life when he looked at me and said, "I have heard a lot about you." The next time I met him was during the Emergency when he was practically



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to stage a play during lunch time, to distract the jailor's attention. The whole of that day JP pretended to be ill. As the play commenced, he along with his comrades made a run for it, succeeding in jumping over the fence.

There are accounts of how JP was much more sheltered than his friends perhaps because of his years spent abroad. Tales abound of shoes and clothes being especially arranged so that he could survive the harsh outdoors. It is said that during his escape from the prison he had hurt his foot and his friend Shukla carried him on his back through the rest of

1974, there was immense political tension. The Congress secured a landslide victory in 1971 but by then the sheen had worn off and the chinks were beginning to show. The mass discontent coupled with the Allahabad High Court verdict against Indira Gandhi consolidated the whole energy into one mass movement. And there could be no greater testimony to JP's appeal than the student protests that broke out across Bihar in 1974. The reasons were close to his heart: corruption, unemployment and inhumanity. One particular protest remains etched in my mind:

on the run. He smiled and said, "Everyone's in, how come you are left out?" I felt the power of his political beliefs then.

JP for everyone was an icon. He swam against the tide and did whatever he believed in. It is that which continues to inspire thousands of Indians now. He lived for his beliefs and did not mind dying for them. For him losing freedom was tolerable if the nation breathed free.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

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Q: When did JP's brush with Marxism begin?

A: While studying at the University of Wisconsin-Madison under sociologist Edward A. Ross

Q: Which organisations did he establish?

A: Citizens for Democracy in 1974 and the People's Union for Civil Liberties in 1976

Q: When did he call for *sampoorna kranti* (total revolution)?

A: In 1975, at a students' rally in Patna

Q: His death was erroneously announced by the then PM in March 1979. When did JP pass away?

A: October 8, 1979

Q: Which university has been set up in his memory?

A: JP University, Chhapra, Bihar